At the same time, stories began emerging on the 'conversion crorepatis'. Reports of highly innovative methods of money laundering[6] came in from across the country. Highly publicized and vulgarly ostentatious weddings[7] of the children of prominent politicians also started making the headlines.

As the common citizen struggled with withdrawal limits and an acute shortage of cash, national media carried out a series of sting operations. Videos, which soon went viral on social media, showed how the new notes meant for the public were being shamelessly siphoned off by bankers in collusion with corrupt politicians and businessmen.[8] The mood of a silent public, who had borne the pain of demonetization in the hope of a cleaner India, slowly began to turn.

To counter this, the Finance Minister and other officials of the Ministry of Finance (MoF) started making statements on the tax penalties that would be levied on people depositing excessive amounts of cash in their accounts. Frequent contradictions in their statements led to further confusion and the fear that a new income tax 'raid-raj' would be unleashed on the country.

On 22 November, the Prime Minister launched a poll on his personal NAMO App, asking people whether they supported the demonetization. The IT and Telecom Minister, Ravi Shankar Prasad, shared the survey results on 23 November. He said that more than 93 per cent of the five lakh people who participated in the survey supported demonetization.

Prominent economists, both in India and abroad, were vocal in their criticism of the move.

The strong words of the mild-mannered and courteous former Prime Minister, Manmohan Singh, set the tone when he said, 'The *GDP can decline by about two per cent* as a result of what has been done… the way this scheme has been implemented is a monumental management failure, and in fact, it is *a case of organized loot, legalised plunder of the common people*.'[9]